



VED MARWAH
Former Director-
General, National
Security Guards

"Sending in the army would be a recipe for disaster. They would find it even more difficult than the paramilitary forces.

● No. Send in well-trained and well-equipped local police on the Andhra Pradesh 'Greyhounds' model. Strengthen governance in the affected areas.

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**148 PEOPLE WERE
KILLED IN THE
TRAIN CRASH IN
WEST BENGAL
ON MAY 28**



DEBASISH BHADURI

Defence Minister A.K. Antony, who has argued for upgrading the deficient state police forces instead.

In sharp contrast is Chidambaram, who has been vocal in asking for army assistance in countering the Maoists. Chidambaram's surge against the Maoists, which began in 2009, aimed at pumping in CPMs like the CRPF and Border Security Force to prop up the deficient state police forces, bring in development and simultaneously pressure Maoists to negotiate after "abjuring violence". This strategy may appear to have worked well in the past—against Pu Laldenga's Mizo National Front in 1986 and recently with the United Liberation Front of Assam. In March this year, the home minister even laid down a two-year

timeframe for bringing the problem under control. But, with the Maoists on the ascendant militarily, it seems unlikely they will ever come to the negotiating table. It is perhaps this military stalemate that has Chidambaram looking across his office in the North Block towards South Block.

Addressing the armed forces' combined commanders' conference, an annual meet of all the three armed forces top brass, in October last year the voluble Chidambaram compared the Maoists to the Taliban. He chided the army for its apparent double standards in not fighting the Maoists. "Both are driven by ideology. Both use terror as

an instrument of policy. But you are ready to fight the Taliban yet not the Maoists," Chidambaram had reportedly said. The army brass has resisted getting drawn into yet another insurgency. At a presentation made to the home minister by the army's Military Operations Directorate last year, the army recommended that 10 battalions of the CRPF be withdrawn from the valley and redeployed in Chhattisgarh.

The 65 CPMF battalions are already stretched thin through a 40,000 sq km Red Corridor across five states. In contrast, the army deploys 66 RR battalions to contain an insurgency within 4,000 sq km of just one state.

The Home Ministry now plans to throw in 10 more BSF battalions, draw in the Indo-Tibetan Border Police and



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